LE GRUYèRE AOP

THE BASICS



MAKE:	Hardcooked
SUB MAKE:	Alpine style
POST-MAKE:	Washed rind
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TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	Six to 18 months
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	35kg
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	Switzerland
PROTECTED STATUS:	AOP – must be made in the cantons of Fribourg, Vaud, Neuchâtel, Jura, and Berne
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Cow
BREED OF COW:	Not specified
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Raw cows' milk
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Animal rennet
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	Gruyère AOP "Classic"; Gruyère AOP Réserve; Gruyère AOP Bio; Gruyère d'Alpage AOP

THE STORY

This mighty mountain cheese, which can trace its history back to 1115, takes its name from the Swiss market town of Gruyères, where it has long been traded. The cheese is made in around 165 village dairies using milk from farms within 20km and is matured by specialist affineurs for at least five months. Tiny amounts of Gruyère d'Alpage are made during the summer, when the cows are taken high up to graze on mountain pastures and the cheese is often made in small huts using copper cauldrons over open fires.

The starter cultures for Gruyère typically come in the form of whey from the previous day's production. The curd is cut into small grains, stirred and heated to 54-59°C, before being moulded and pressed for a minimum of 16 hours after which the cheeses are either dry-salted or brined. The rind is washed in brine periodically during maturation.

THE CHARACTER

Gruyère Classic is aged for six to nine months and has a pliable texture and sweet flavour. Réserve is matured for at least 10 months, often longer, and has a slightly drier but still waxy texture, plus layers of flavour taking in dairy, fruity and umami notes.

PERFECT PARTNERS:

A wonderful cheese for melting in baked goods and fondue, Gruyère works well with fruity reds, including Burgundy and Côtes du Rhône.

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